

Testing Times

In any magazine, the editorial is force to reckon with. Not only can wage war with words, they also have the power to misspell your name in the magazine, should you ever offend them. At Jasubhai Digital Media, the force is even more easily irked, as they battle to hold their own amongst all the geek-speak.

Synapse devised online tests that each writer, copy-editor and reviewer had to take each Friday—needless to say, without any online assistance. The weekly tests would go on for the next 6 months, speckled with visits to Goa for more hands-on sessions. Now some had been a bit corrupted by sms shrt tlk and 2much time online ;), and others had never really understood the functions of the humble comma. So Friday brought back bitter-sweet memories of school as everyone rushed through the study material at the last minute possible, and *eenie-meennie-mynie-moed* the multiple choices. A few were even bribed to 'proxy' the tests for the others.

As weeks passed by, many felt braver, and lunch-time conversation was about what she wrote for question number 23,



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar

and how he thought 'irksome' meant 'interesting'. Soon there was rubbing one's high scores in the faces of others who scored a percent lower, and how some of the ratings were completely unfair as they did not take into account

the fact that some Web site said the stated answer was wrong!

The entire editorial team closed their respective magazines to attend sessions in Goa. With 40 of us gone, the building is sure to look deserted.

Aliens, Anguish and AMD

There was fervour all around the Digit Test Centre this month. The AMD guys stopped by to drop off their little wonder—the AMD Athlon FX 64. Yippie! 64-bit desktop computing at last! There was much shoving and elbowing to get a glimpse of the 64-bit marvel; there were even fights to settle who got to test it. The AMD representatives, in turn, were the object of a tirade of questions, varying from "What's 64-bit?" (obviously not a TC guy), "When do you see a market for 64-bit applications in India?", (the marketing) to "I want 64-bit games!" (that was Badri Narayan, our in-house gaming specialist). Arvind Chandrasekar, Technical Specialist AMD, was intrigued by the TC's Streamsicle streaming music server

concoction, and spent a while listening to Badri boast about it.

This was an opportunity that just couldn't be ignored, and despite the fact that there were only 72 hours left for issue closing, it was decided that the Athlon 64 just had to be tested. Praveen Kurup was selected to test it, and all hell broke loose. The first thing everyone realised was that we didn't have any 64-bit applications or operating systems. After much deliberation and arguing, it was decided that the Athlon 64 would have to be tested in Pure Legacy (32-bit) mode. Praveen ran into a wall with this—all the benchmarks we had were just not designed or optimised for the Athlon 64, and he got some strange results. Even AMD's own 32-bit proces-

sors fared better than the 64-bit wonder. Scratching his head, pacing about the office like a barmy scientist, he was a hysterical wreck.

Meanwhile, Badri was busy running the SETI client on the Athlon64. He sat staring at the screen yelling, "Hey, I'm the first human to search for Extra Terrestrial Intelligence on a 64-bit computer!"

Finally Praveen had a Eureka moment, came trotting back in, promptly deleted SETI, flicked Badri away, and got to work. The solution? Load Linux, compile Unix benchmarks and test the processor.

So the latest catchphrase around the office is '64-bit', and it seems that we may be headed that way a little sooner than we expected.